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The End of Comparative Philosophy and the Task of Comparative Thinking

By Steven Burik

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As the title of his book indicates Steven Burik has taken on an ambitious project: to end comparative philosophy as we know it and inaugurate a new age of comparative thinking. Burik wants to repeat Martin Heidegger's well-known move to end philosophy and begin the task of thinking—but within the field of comparative philosophy. According to Burik, the problem with comparative philosophy is that Western languages are so 'infested with metaphysics' that 'every intercultural dialogue in a Western language risks the danger of corrupting the thoughts of other cultures' (41). In order to overcome this problem, Burik suggests that 'we must make an effort at real *Auseinandersetzung*' with other cultures (42). *Auseinandersetzung* is Heidegger's term for his own unique way of engaging the western philosophical tradition and early Greek philosophy in particular. Burik wants to reenact Heidegger's way of reading in the field of comparative philosophy and Daoist studies.

At times the mimicking of Heidegger's interpretive style forces Burik into extreme positions. As is well known, Heidegger's readings of early Greek philosophers are forceful, even violent, and they often go against philological consensus. Burik wants to transfer this way of reading to the field of Daoist studies, for, as he writes, '[w]e cannot learn from other cultures if we adhere to strict definitions. In comparative philosophy, therefore, we are not to be hindered by conventions on translation or on what is commonly called "knowledge"' (44). That may be the case, but one cannot creatively break the conventions of translation if one does not know them to begin with. Here we come to the key problem with Burik's whole argument, which, to his credit, Burik himself states clearly. Towards the end of his "Introduction" Burik writes 'I realize that in the ideal circumstances I would have to have proficiency in the classical Chinese language. But nevertheless I think that even without this proficiency and with just some acquaintance with classical Chinese, I can still make a valuable contribution' (9). It may be possible to make a valuable contribution to the study of Daoist philosophy without knowing classical Chinese, and one could, I suppose, make a contribution to the study of classical Chinese language without knowing the language by summarizing the findings of scholars who do know the

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language. But it is not possible, as Burik proposes, to have a confrontation (*Auseinandersetzung*) with Daoism in the style of Heidegger's confrontation with early Greek thinkers without knowing the language in and through which the Daoists think. From the point of view of Heidegger (and Derrida) it is impossible to engage a philosopher one cannot read in the original language at this profound level, and the very question of the suitability of a metaphysical interpretation of Daoism, which Burik takes upon himself, cannot be determined without close reading of the primary texts. The problem of not knowing classical Chinese becomes acute in chapter three, when Burik 'rereads' Daoism 'the other way.'

First there are two chapters that summarize features of Heidegger and Derrida that Burik believes are important for comparative philosophy. These chapters give some interesting suggestions of what Heidegger and Derrida may have to contribute to comparative philosophy (neither of them engaged directly in the discipline), but on the whole one gets the impression that the main lesson comparative philosophers can gain from reading Heidegger and Derrida is 'to keep an open mind' (43, 44, 64, 72-73, 85, 99) and 'not try to read too much into them [the texts] that is just not there' (45-46). Presumably these injunctions are quite familiar to Western interpreters of Daoism.

In chapter three Burik offers 'a different-from-the-standard reading of some of the classical texts of Daoism' (86). The standard reading is the metaphysical reading, and Burik proposes a reading of Daoism 'that does not presuppose any transcendent quality' (88). Burik summarily brushes aside many translators and interpreters of Daoism: Herbert Giles, Wing-tsit Chan, Herrlee Creel, Arthur Waley, Burton Watson, Fung Yu-lan, D. C. Lau, Isabelle Robinet, Benjamin Schwartz, and Max Kaltenmark. Among these are some of the greatest translators of classical Chinese, and one may wonder how Burik, who does not read Chinese, is able to see where they fail. Burik relies on authority. On nearly every page of the book we read phrases such as 'as Hall and Ames have made clear' (94), or '[a]s Ames and Hall have explained' (141). If a given translation or interpretation of Daoism does not conform to the views of Roger Ames and David Hall (and a few other like-minded scholars) then, according to Burik, they are not suitable representations of Daoist sensibilities.

Burik has a whole section on interpretations of classical Chinese language (101-113), but this section simply summarizes the views of Ames and Hall, and Chad Hansen. If one is interested in the philosophical implications of classical Chinese language a good place to begin would be Christoph Harbsmeier's *Language and Logic in Traditional China* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998). This work is as authoritative as they get, but it is not even mentioned by Burik, perhaps because Harbsmeier says that Daoists (Zhuangzi) enter 'a higher metaphysical realm' (236) and thereby shows that he has not grasped the nonmetaphysical implications of Daoism. Burik does refer to A. C. Graham, who is also authoritative on classical Chinese, but only selectively, and Graham's understanding of the Dao as an 'unnamable whole' and 'nothing less than the universe flowing from its ultimate source (not just the course of its flow, which would be to make a distinction)' (*Disputers of the Tao*, La Salle: Open

Court, 1998, p. 188) must clearly be considered unsuitable from Burik's nonmetaphysical point of view.

According to Burik there is no transcendence in Daoism, and he summarily sets aside a number of scholars who have argued for some sense of transcendence in Daoism. Burik says that even if François Jullien writes as if he accepts the language of transcendence, Jullien really 'does not endorse the metaphysical way of thinking,' and it would be better, in order to prevent misunderstanding, if he would refrain from using metaphysical language at all, 'as Ames and Hall urge us to do' (117). Chung-ying Cheng, who writes 'Dao and God are two names that represent two forms of ultimate reality,' is, of course, completely unsuitable for understanding Daoism. The same goes for Robert Cummings Neville who, according to Burik, reads negative theology into Daoism. Burik also discusses my own interpretation of Zhuangzi, and again the argument is settled by reference to authority: 'As Hall and Ames have argued, this insertion of metaphysical vocabulary is unnecessary and only leads to confusion' (118).

We are now two thirds into the chapter on 'rereading Daoism' and as yet there has not appeared any textual evidence for Burik's interpretation. To his credit, Burik is aware of the problem: 'it is insufficient to merely state different views from different scholars of Chinese thinking about transcendence and metaphysics and choose the one we like best. That would amount to underwriting the sometimes highly selective reading of certain scholars' (120). In the last pages of the chapter Burik does consider some passages from Daoist texts, but, clearly, not enough to substantiate his sweeping claims about the nature of Daoist thought. Furthermore, several of the translations of Daoist texts are by Hall and Ames and therefore predisposed towards the nonmetaphysical orientation that Burik wants to find in them.

In chapter four Burik compares Daoism with Heidegger and Derrida. This chapter is supposed to show Burik's new way of doing comparative thinking. Burik first sets aside a number of other scholars who have compared Heidegger or Derrida with Daoism but are still stuck in metaphysical thinking. Chang Chung-yuan makes the mistake of finding mysticism in Daoism and Heidegger. Graham Parkes mistakenly writes of an 'absolute Nothing,' for, '[a]s Ames and Hal have explained,' there is no such ontological category in Daoism. Kitarõ Nishida and Keiji Nishitani of the Kyoto school are stuck in metaphysics as they compare Chinese thought and Heidegger. Hwa Yol Jung has 'a very superficial understanding' of Derrida, Edward T. Ch'ien 'does not do justice to Derrida,' and in his comparison of Derrida and Chinese thought Zhang Longxi also falls back into metaphysics (139-145).

Burik then presents his own comparison of Daoism and Heidegger and Derrida, which is supposed to avoid metaphysical reading and be more suitable than the 'misunderstandings,' 'misapplications,' and 'one-sided approaches' Burik has just set aside. Burik does not really, however, present a comparative reading of Heidegger and Derrida, on the one hand, and Daoism, on the other. He compares rather Daoism as understood by Ames and Hall with the philosophies of Heidegger and Derrida. This means that in Burik's comparison the Daoist text is not read at all but simply understood as it is interpreted by others, and, in my

opinion, Burik does not read Heidegger properly either. At one point Burik worries that some readers may not understand that 'the Heideggerian jargon I have employed throughout this book' is well suited to a 'nonmetaphysical reading of Daoism' and 'to convey a different way of thinking' (154-55). The problem is not, however, that some readers may not see the point of using Heidegger to understand Daoism, but that Burik reduces Heidegger's discourse to, precisely, 'jargon.' Heidegger's most profound figures of thought are quickly summarized to the point of becoming trivial, even nonsensical, and in this form they are compared with Daoist figures of thought that have been subjected to the same treatment.

According to Burik, one feature that shows 'the closeness of Heidegger to Laozi' is that both 'tend to write in an obscure fashion,' and this obscurity has a similar function in both philosophers: in Heidegger obscurity helps to show 'interdependence and relationality of unconcealing and concealing. In the case of Laozi, the obscurity in the writing is similarly a calling attention of the retreat of things profound into darkness, an acknowledgement again of the untraceable trace-character of the world' (158-59). According to Burik, what Daoism, Derrida and Heidegger have in common 'is the acknowledgment of the play of different forces that shape and guide (our understanding of) the world,' (180) and this 'constant play of differences' is 'alternatively called Being, difference, or *dao*' (189). According to the conventions of nonmetaphysical thinking we cannot say that these comparisons are 'wrong,' and I leave it to the reader to decide how 'suitable' they are.

In the last pages of the book, Burik addresses the question of whether his nonmetaphysical interpretation of Daoism is historically and culturally accurate. Burik says that he is not qualified to judge, but he adds that if his nonmetaphysical interpretation of Daoism does not fit 'our preconceived ideas of the cultural and historical sphere of the ancient Chinese, these preconceived interpretations might themselves stand in need of rereading in the same way.' It has been Burik's intention to think 'more Daoist' than the Daoists, just like Heidegger wanted to think 'more Greek' than the Greek themselves, and in fulfilling this task 'the real challenge lies in making the ancients speak to us, and in thinking through them in such a way that we can think what they maybe left unthought or what was passed over in the history of subsequent interpretations' (191). It is, however, plainly impossible to think through Daoism this way without reading Daoism in the original language—which involves knowing some history and culture as well. The question of metaphysics and transcendence in Daoism—and also in Heidegger and Derrida—is much more complicated than Burik thinks, and it is precisely the ambivalence and unsettledness of the question of transcendence in both Chinese and Western philosophy that should set the task for real comparative thinking.